

8.5 Social Voice Chat

Chatting over the internet is now passé. To go beyond a step of this form of entertainment, Cellebrum Pvt. Ltd. is offering mobile phone carriers the ability to provide mobile subscribers with "Social Voice Chatting". Social Voice Chat is a service for mobile subscribers who wish to talk not only with known acquaintances but also to any unknown person without disclosing their identity.

How does it work?

In a soft launch conducted by various mobile phone carriers across telecom circles, the service is started by the phone subscriber receiving a SMS asking him if he/she wants to make friends. Users register for the service by replying back on a certain number and are assigned a five-digit code by the system that also acts as their mobile number on the social network, thus hiding their real phone number. They can then dial a three-digit number and listen to other people describing themselves and try to reach them by dialling their code. Users getting the calls are not obligated to answer them.

Each such call costs Rs 3 a minute both for the caller and the receiver of the call. This was introduced to avoid gaming of the system where people would make long distance calls under the pretext of Social Voice Chatting.

It is said that unlike social Web sites, the demographics of the search cannot be defined just yet. Meaning, you get access to all the people who have registered for this service across the country and there is no way to pick and choose any state or telecom circle or any other demographic.

In Parting

We feel that this idea has a lot of potential. Quite a few mobile phone users do not have a computer, let alone access to the internet. In such a scenario, the attractiveness of indulging in social networking for people who pay on an hourly rate for access to the internet would be all too great. Another moot point is the price of